

THE NEW SUPER COP

With his hands-on approach and corporate-like accountability, P. Chidambaram has transformed the inert Home Ministry. But is Mr Tough a long-distance runner?

By Raj Chengappa

It is no secret that Palaniappan Chidambaram would have preferred to remain Union Finance Minister. The office at the opposite end of North Block that he has occupied ever since Shivraj Patil was sacked after 26/11 commands a magnificent view of India Gate. But he is not impressed by this perk or the fact that as Union Home Minister he oversees an array of vital functions of the government that, if exercised in full, could make him the second-most powerful man in the country. After all, the Mumbai attacks and the spate of Maoist strikes have made internal security as big a challenge for India as the recession.

Yet, Chidambaram candidly admits to friends that the Finance Ministry, which formulates policies that could set the direction for the nation, remains his first love. For him Home is more reactive—to terror, to insurgency, to communal disharmony—rather than pace setting. He looks at his current job largely as one of “building capacity, competence and confidence”. Praise from experts for transforming his moribund ministry within a short span of 11 months by infusing it with a new resoluteness and assurance is shrugged off with, “Look, I am just doing my job.”

Though it may seem strange to laud someone for just doing his job, in a ministry replete with failure and apathy, Chidambaram is an outstanding exception and has emerged as India's new super cop. When he took over on the eve of 2009, India had seen a series of deadly terror strikes with 26/11 being the most brazen of them all. There was a sense that the internal situation in India was slipping out of control. A year later, the flailing has been replaced by an obvious confidence and steel—reflecting the personality of the incumbent head of the Home Ministry. What helps is that there has been no major cross-border attack since Mumbai. Chidambaram is the first to acknowledge that this is “primarily because of luck and then to things that we have been doing”. What has also made a difference is that Pakistan has been too occupied with staving off an internal implosion to

unleash its dogs of war.

When he was invited to address the India summit of the World Economic Forum recently, dressed in his characteristic *veshti*, Chidambaram was quite at home with the pin-striped suited leaders of the corporate community. Chidambaram knew he had to assure investors, both foreign and domestic, that India was no more vulnerable than other developed countries. That he did with a great deal of gravitas and credibility. When asked specifically whether post-26/11, India was safer, his reply was firm: “We believe that we have the capacity to thwart any attack. Should there be an attack, we believe we have the capacity to contain it and respond in a swift and decisive manner.”

That statement was also directed towards Pakistan with

“We now have the capacity to thwart any attack. Should there be an attack, we believe we have the capacity to contain it and respond in a swift and decisive manner.”

P. CHIDAMBARAM, Home Minister

Chidambaram playing the role of India's tough cop to perfection by implicitly threatening Pakistan with retaliation if there was another 26/11 or major terror strike. On the question of bringing the perpetrators of Mumbai to book, he is never shy of saying, “Pakistan has done very little. What have they done?” That invariably led to voluble denials from Rehman Malik, his counterpart in the Pakistan Government. But since the arrest of David Coleman Headley, Malik has maintained television silence. At one of his routine morning meetings with the head of India's intelligence agencies, Chidambaram couldn't resist taking a dig and asked: “Can Pakistan now deny that Headley has no connection with it?”

The morning intelligence review meeting which Chidambaram personally conducts every day has been one of the hallmarks of his success. Among the first things he did after assuming charge was to go through the 26/11 dossiers to find out the lapses. It was obvious that one of the main reasons was the massive systemic failure in intelligence. Information was neither being gathered in real time by the respective agencies nor shared and analysed on a real time basis. It was not that the Indian agencies did not have prior information about the attack—they did. But as he says, “Everybody lost sight of what A told B and nobody connected the dots.” To emphasise the